

# 26th Annual Carolina Cup

October 2–4, 2026 • Columbia &amp; Irmo, South Carolina

Welcome to our Carolina Cup guide. We put this together so everything about the weekend — travel, lodging, the venue, and what we're still waiting on from the tournament — lives in one place instead of scattered across emails and the group chat. As the tournament releases more information, we'll send updated versions of this same guide.

## At a Glance

The one-minute version. If you read nothing else, read this.

|            |                                                                                         |
|------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Where      | Complex not yet assigned<br>Five SCUFC complexes • Columbia / Irmo, SC                  |
| When       | Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026                                             |
| Bracket    | Under 10 Boys Red Division                                                              |
| Drive      | ~169 miles • ~3h 15min from Savannah                                                    |
| Hotel      | Country Inn & Suites at Harbison — \$161/night<br>Harbison cluster • cheapest confirmed |
| Do today   | Book the hotel — hold a free-cancellation rate while you decide                         |
| Waiting on | Game schedule & field assignments (Sep 24)                                              |

## 1. Tournament Quick Start

Everything a busy parent needs, in under a minute.

|       |                                             |
|-------|---------------------------------------------|
| Event | 26th Annual Carolina Cup                    |
| Host  | South Carolina United FC (SCUFC)            |
| Team  | Savannah United 16/17B Premier              |
| Dates | Friday, October 2 – Sunday, October 4, 2026 |

|              |                                                                        |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Venue        | Complex not yet assigned<br>Five SCUFC complexes · Columbia / Irmo, SC |
| Age Group    | U10 • 7v7 format                                                       |
| Bracket      | Under 10 Boys Red Division                                             |
| Format       | Group play → knockout rounds                                           |
| Entry Fee    | \$725 per team for U8–U10 (7v7)                                        |
| Check-in     | <b>Online check-in only.</b> There is no on-site check-in.             |
| Stay-to-Play | Not published — see Section 6                                          |
| Drive        | ~169 miles • ~3h 15min via US-17 N → I-95 N → I-26 W                   |
| Parking      | Free on-site at SCUFC complexes                                        |

## 2. Parent Action Items

### DO THIS NOW

#### ☐ Book your hotel

Re-checked live on September 18, 2026. Our top pick is now the Country Inn & Suites at Harbison at **\$161 per night**; the Hampton Inn Harbison did not come back as available and we have withdrawn it. See Section 6 for the full list.

### ACTION REQUIRED

#### ☐ Complete online check-in

The accepted team list posted on September 14 and Savannah United 16/17B Premier is confirmed on it. SCUFC states that online check-in is open and that teams should start it **immediately**. There is **no on-site check-in** at this event, so this cannot be handled at the field. Re-verified September 18, 2026.

### BRACKET POSTED — SEPTEMBER 16

#### ☐ Know who is in your bracket

Our division is **Under 10 Boys Red Division**. Section 3 lists every team we could meet. The game-by-game schedule — pairings, kickoff times and fields — posts September 24; we'll send the updated guide with calculated departure times for each family.

### BEFORE LEAVING HOME

#### ☐ Pack using the checklist

Section 12 has the full list. Early October in the Midlands swings from about 63°F in the morning to around 80°F in the afternoon — bring layers as well as heat gear.

### BEFORE LEAVING HOME

#### □ Review the tournament rules

SCUFC has not published the 2026 rules document yet. Section 13 explains what we know and what we're still waiting on.

### 3. What We Know & What We're Waiting For

#### Confirmed

**Official Tournament Information:** 26th Annual Carolina Cup, October 2–4, 2026, hosted by South Carolina United FC in the Columbia/Irmo area of South Carolina.

**Official Tournament Information:** Open to boys and girls teams, U8 through U19, at Recreational, Intermediate, and Advanced levels. U8–U10 play 7v7.

**Official Tournament Information:** All teams must complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in.

**Official Tournament Information:** Tournament director is Tripp Miller (tripp@scufc.com). SCUFC phone: 877-457-2832.

**Confirmed Team Information:** Savannah United 16/17B Premier is accepted and scheduled to attend.

#### Pending Confirmation

**Confirmed:** Savannah United 16/17B Premier is on the official accepted team list (10U Boys). Online check-in is required — there is no on-site check-in.

**Confirmed:** our bracket is **Under 10 Boys Red Division** — 6 teams in total. Opponents in our division:

- BU10 Black (SC Surf)
- CESA U10B Pre ECNL-RL Summit-1
- JIYSC U10 Boys Red Roncancio
- SCUFC U10 Boys Blue
- SCUFC U10 Boys Red

Verified at the source on the tournament site. The game-by-game pairings, kickoff times and fields are published with the full schedule on September 24, 2026.

**Pending Confirmation:** Game schedule and field assignments — posted September 24, 2026.

**Pending Confirmation:** Which of the five SCUFC complexes our team plays at, and the field within it.

**Pending Confirmation:** Whether a stay-to-play housing requirement applies. No policy has been published.

**Pending Confirmation:** The 2026 tournament rules document, including game length, mercy rule and tiebreakers.

**Pending Confirmation:** Coach instructions on arrival times, uniform and team-specific details.

### 4. Tournament Overview

The Carolina Cup is run by South Carolina United FC and is now in its 26th year. It draws teams from across the Southeast to five complexes across

the Columbia and Irmo area, and it has been one of the region's larger youth soccer weekends for a long time. Our U10 team will play 7v7.

**Official Tournament Page (SincSports):**

[soccer.sincsports.com](https://soccer.sincsports.com) — [Carolina Cup](#)

**Host Club:**

[southcarolinaunitedfc.com](https://southcarolinaunitedfc.com)

**Official Rules Document:**

Not yet published for 2026

## 5. Travel & Arrival Planning

### Drive from Savannah

Route: US-17 North → I-95 North (about 80 miles) → I-26 West (about 67 miles) → US-76 into Irmo.

Total: ~169 miles. Routing re-verified September 18, 2026 (168.9 mi / 3h 12min, free-flow).

| Scenario                  | Time      | Notes                    |
|---------------------------|-----------|--------------------------|
| Free-flow driving         | ~3h 15min | Routing engine, no stops |
| With a fuel and rest stop | ~3h 35min | Add ~20 min              |
| Friday evening traffic    | ~4h 00min | Add ~45 min              |

**Why the first number is the real one:** the free-flow figure of ~3h 15min is the routing calculation for the most direct route with no stops. The 3h 35min and 4h 00min figures are our own additions for a rest stop and for Friday evening traffic — they are planning buffers, not separate route measurements.

### Player Report Time

**Pending Confirmation.** Game times are released September 24. Once we have them, we'll calculate each family's departure time so players arrive at the field **45 minutes before kickoff** for check-in, warm-up, and coach instructions.

**Parent Manager Recommendation:** An overnight stay avoids a pre-dawn Saturday drive. Two nights (Friday October 2 and Saturday October 3) is the pattern most traveling families use for this event.

## 6. Lodging

**Housing requirement:** SCUFC has not published a stay-to-play policy for the Carolina Cup. We checked the official tournament page, the host club site, and the registration portal, and found no stated hotel requirement or approved-hotel list. **Pending Confirmation** — we will confirm directly with the

tournament director (Tripp Miller, [tripp@scufc.com](mailto:tripp@scufc.com)) and update this section. Our recommendation is to book a cancellable rate now rather than wait.

## Where to stay — re-checked September 18

We re-ran availability for October 2–4 (one room, two adults, one child) and the picture has changed. Our previous first pick, the **Hampton Inn on Harbison Blvd**, **did not come back as available** in any search, so we have stopped recommending it. The **Country Inn & Suites at Harbison is confirmed at \$161 per night** and is now our top pick — cheaper than the Hampton we had been suggesting. The **Harbison** cluster (northwest Columbia, off I-26) is where the availability is; **Irmo** itself is closest to the complexes but nearly full.

## Best options right now

**Why several distances?** The Carolina Cup runs across five SCUFC complexes and the tournament does not assign our teams to one until the schedule posts on September 24. A hotel that is closest to Ballentine Park can be the furthest from Polo Road Park — so we show every complex rather than guess. Once each team's complex is known, that team's guide and app will lead with the hotel closest to *its* field. Distances in this section are driving distances, routing-verified in Google Maps where marked; unmarked figures are router estimates awaiting the same check.

### Country Inn & Suites by Radisson, Columbia at Harbison

Rate: \$161 per night • \$322 for two nights  
Area: Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)  
Notes: Our pick — the cheapest confirmed Harbison room  
Distance to field: SE Freight 8.3 mi / ~13 min • Ballentine Park 9.8 mi / ~14 min (Google Maps) • Polo Road Park 17.2 mi / ~25 min • SV Presbyterian 18.7 mi / ~28 min

### WoodSpring Suites Columbia – Irmo

Rate: \$189 per night • \$423 for two nights  
Area: Irmo — the closest town to the complexes  
Notes: Extended-stay style  
Distance to field: SE Freight 6.3 mi / ~11 min • Ballentine Park 12.2 mi / ~19 min • Polo Road Park 15.2 mi / ~22 min • SV Presbyterian 16.8 mi / ~25 min

### Hilton Garden Inn Columbia/Harbison

Rate: \$273 per night • \$611 for two nights  
Area: Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)  
Notes: Restaurant on site, pool  
Distance to field: Ballentine Park 5.7 mi / ~12 min (Google Maps) • SE Freight 10.3 mi / ~17 min • Polo Road Park 19.2 mi / ~29 min • SV Presbyterian 20.8 mi / ~31 min

### MainStay Suites Columbia Harbison

Rate: \$279 per night • \$625 for two nights  
Area: Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)

Notes: Suite-style with kitchenette

Distance to field: Ballentine Park 5.7 mi / ~11 min • SE Freight 10.3 mi / ~17 min  
• Polo Road Park 19.3 mi / ~29 min • SV Presbyterian 20.8 mi / ~32 min

### Hyatt Place Columbia/Harbison

Rate: \$367 per night • \$821 for two nights

Area: Harbison cluster (northwest Columbia)

Notes: Now cheaper than when we first checked

Distance to field: Ballentine Park 5.5 mi / ~10 min • SE Freight 11.0 mi / ~17 min  
• Polo Road Park 19.9 mi / ~29 min • SV Presbyterian 21.4 mi / ~31 min

### Also available — further out

|                                                     |                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| Comfort Suites Columbia at Harbison                 | \$308/nt • Harbison cluster                      |
| LivSmart Studios by Hilton Columbia Greystone       | \$315/nt • Greystone                             |
| Tru by Hilton Harbison Columbia                     | \$319/nt • Harbison — not the Greystone property |
| La Quinta Inn by Wyndham Columbia SE / Fort Jackson | \$171/nt • SE Columbia, longer drive             |
| SpringHill Suites by Marriott Camden                | \$213/nt • Camden, allow 35–40 min               |
| Leesville Lodge                                     | \$194/nt • Lexington side, basic property        |
| Motel 6 West Columbia – Airport                     | \$173/nt • budget option                         |

Marriott Bonvoy eligible from this list: SpringHill Suites Camden. The Residence Inn and TownePlace Suites in Lexington did not come back as available, and neither did the Tru by Hilton Greystone or the Ramada Limited.

**Important:** These rates were pulled live on **September 18, 2026** from a Hotels.com search scoped to October 2–4 for one room, two adults and one child, and they will change. This is a **partial result set, not full inventory** — a hotel that does not appear here is unknown, not necessarily sold out. The two-night figures include taxes and fees. We have deliberately not published driving distances: the tournament has not yet assigned which of its five complexes our teams play at, and quoting a distance to the wrong one would be worse than quoting none. Book a free-cancellation rate and re-check before you travel.

## 7. Weather & Heat Planning

**We are nearly three weeks out**, so a daily forecast is not yet meaningful. What follows is what early October has actually looked like in Columbia over

the past ten years, so families can plan clothing and hydration sensibly.

#### Typical early-October conditions in Columbia

|                |                                                             |
|----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------|
| Afternoon high | Around 80°F on average — has reached 95°F                   |
| Morning low    | Around 63°F — noticeably cool at the first game             |
| Rain           | Roughly a 1-in-6 chance of measurable rain on any given day |
| Sun            | Strong — open complexes with limited shade                  |
| Best games     | Morning games are meaningfully cooler than afternoon        |

#### What this means for packing

This is a two-wardrobe weekend. Bring the heat gear — water, electrolytes, sunscreen, cooling towels — but also bring a jacket or warm layer for early mornings and a rain shell, because October in the Midlands is not August. Start hydrating the day before travel.

Based on ten years of recorded daily observations for Columbia, SC. **Check the actual forecast around September 28–30** for reliable day-by-day conditions. Source data: Open-Meteo historical archive (2016–2025).

## 8. Venue, Parking & Fields

**Official Tournament Information:** The Carolina Cup is played across five SCUFC complexes in the Columbia and Irmo area. Our team's specific complex and field will be assigned when the schedule is posted on September 24. Below are all five, so you can see where you might be going.

#### Ballentine Park Complex

1009 Bickley Road, Irmo, SC 29063

Listed as the tournament's primary venue on the event listing.

#### SCUFC West Soccer Complex

1053 Bird Road, Irmo, SC 29063

#### Polo Road Park

730 Polo Road, Columbia, SC 29229

#### Southeastern Freight Lines Soccer Center

115 Sunbelt Blvd, Columbia, SC 29203

#### SV Presbyterian Church Fields

125 Sparkleberry Lane, Columbia, SC 29229

#### Parking

|             |                                                              |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Cost        | Free — SCUFC complexes have on-site parking                  |
| Fill time   | Fills early on tournament mornings                           |
| Fields      | Grass; specific field layouts published per complex by SCUFC |
| Amenities   | Concessions and restrooms at the complexes                   |
| Tent policy | <b>Pending Confirmation</b> — not published                  |

**Official field layouts (published by SCUFC):**

[Ballentine Park field layout](#)

[SCUFC West field layout](#)

[Polo Road Park field layout](#)

[Southeastern Freight Lines field layout](#)

**Parent Manager Recommendation:** Arrive 30–45 minutes before your first game to secure parking and walk to your field. These are large, spread-out complexes.

## 9. Team Communication Plan

|                      |                              |
|----------------------|------------------------------|
| Official schedule    | SincSports (Carolina Cup)    |
| Team updates         | PlayMetrics Messages • Email |
| Tournament logistics | Parent Manager               |
| Soccer questions     | Coach                        |
| Urgent changes       | Team chat / text             |

An updated guide will be sent as soon as the schedule is released.

## 10. Coach Updates (Coming Soon)

This section will be updated once our coaches release arrival times, uniform details, and any team-specific instructions.

*Parents do not need to act on these items — they are for reference once confirmed by the coaching staff.*

## 11. Player Guidance

Tournament weekends are exciting and demanding for young players. A few practical reminders.

- Prioritize sleep — early bedtimes Friday and Saturday
- Keep meals familiar — not the weekend for new foods
- Bring simple, preferred snacks
- Encourage steady hydration through the day
- Limit exhausting hotel-pool activity before games
- Bring quiet activities for downtime between games
- Expect physical and emotional fatigue
- Keep postgame conversations positive and brief
- Let coaches handle the soccer instruction
- Emphasize effort, teamwork, learning, and fun

## 12. Packing Checklist

### Player Gear

- ☐ Both uniform kits
- ☐ Cleats
- ☐ Shin guards
- ☐ Labeled water bottle
- ☐ Extra socks
- ☐ Warm-up / training gear
- ☐ Dry clothes
- ☐ Recovery shoes or sandals
- ☐ Personal medications
- ☐ Warm layer for early games

### Weather & Hydration

- ☐ Water (plenty)
- ☐ Electrolytes
- ☐ Sunscreen (SPF 50+)
- ☐ Cooling towel
- ☐ Rain gear / shell
- ☐ Small fan
- ☐ Plastic bags for wet gear
- ☐ Extra blanket or jacket

### Parent Sideline

- ☐ Folding chairs
- ☐ Umbrella
- ☐ Cooler
- ☐ Snacks
- ☐ Portable charger
- ☐ Wipes
- ☐ Trash bags
- ☐ Activities for siblings
- ☐ Cash for concessions
- ☐ Shade if permitted

### Emergency

- ☐ Basic first-aid supplies
- ☐ Ice packs
- ☐ Insurance information
- ☐ Emergency contacts
- ☐ Prescriptions

## 13. Tournament Rules

### Pending Confirmation

SCUFC has not published the 2026 Carolina Cup rules document. Game length, mercy rule, substitution rules, and the tiebreaker order are all still unconfirmed for this year. **We will not guess at these.** As soon as the rules

are published we'll add the full breakdown — including the complete tiebreaker hierarchy — to this section and resend the guide.

#### What we do know

|             |                                              |
|-------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Format      | 7v7 for U8–U10 age groups                    |
| Age groups  | U8–U19, boys and girls                       |
| Levels      | Recreational, Intermediate, Advanced         |
| Sanctioning | US Youth Soccer affiliated (SC Youth Soccer) |
| Check-in    | Online only — no on-site check-in            |

**Rules questions:** Tournament Director Tripp Miller — [tripp@scufc.com](mailto:tripp@scufc.com)

**Bracket questions (U8–U12):** Jamie McClendon — [jamie@scufc.com](mailto:jamie@scufc.com)

## 14. Nearby Family Resources

Distances measured from Ballentine Park Complex — the one listing sites name as the primary venue, but **only one of the five possible complexes**. Information current as of September 18, 2026.

#### Closest to the venue

|                     |                                |
|---------------------|--------------------------------|
| CVS Pharmacy        | 0.3 mi                         |
| Food Lion           | 0.4 mi                         |
| Walmart Supercenter | 1.1 mi • 1180 Dutch Fork Road  |
| Publix              | 2.3 mi • 2732 North Lake Drive |

#### Forgot something?

|                           |                             |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------|
| Dick's Sporting Goods     | 6.2 mi • 1110 Bower Parkway |
| Academy Sports + Outdoors | 6.2 mi                      |

#### Near the Harbison hotel cluster

|              |                        |
|--------------|------------------------|
| Trader Joe's | 275 Harbison Boulevard |
| Publix       | 150 Harbison Boulevard |
| Rite Aid     | 5.1 mi from the venue  |

## 15. Weekend Itinerary

Friday, October 2

Travel day for most families. Leave Savannah by early afternoon — about 3h 15min in free-flow conditions and closer to 4 hours with traffic and a stop.

### Saturday, October 3

**Pending Confirmation.** Schedule releases September 24. Player report time is 45 minutes before each kickoff.

### Sunday, October 4

**Pending Confirmation.** Depends on Saturday's results. Plan checkout and departure around whether your team advances.

## 16. Quick Reference

Screenshot this for game day.

|                 |                                                      |
|-----------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| Tournament      | 26th Annual Carolina Cup                             |
| Team            | Savannah United 16/17B Premier                       |
| Dates           | Oct 2–4, 2026                                        |
| Venue           | Complex not yet assigned • five SCUFC complexes      |
| Venue confirmed | With the schedule on Sep 24                          |
| Drive           | ~169 mi • ~3h 15min                                  |
| Hotel           | Country Inn & Suites Harbison • \$161/nt             |
| Format          | U10 • 7v7                                            |
| Check-in        | Online only — opens after Sep 14                     |
| Weather         | ~63°F morning / ~80°F afternoon • layers + heat gear |
| Director        | Tripp Miller • tripp@scufc.com                       |
| SCUFC           | 877-457-2832                                         |

## 17. Final Next Steps

1. **Book your hotel now.** The Irmo area was 80% booked when we checked. A free-cancellation rate costs nothing to hold.
2. **Watch for the accepted team list on September 14,** then complete online check-in. There is no on-site check-in at this tournament.
3. **Check the bracket September 16** and the **schedule September 24.** We'll send a refreshed guide with departure times once game times are live.

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4. **Pack for two climates** — cool mornings, warm afternoons, and a real chance of rain.
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5. **Check the forecast around September 28–30** for reliable day-by-day conditions.

### **Go, SU 16/17B Premier!**

Looking forward to a great weekend in Columbia. Safe travels, and we'll send the updated guide as soon as the schedule drops.

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Savannah United 16/17B Premier • 26th Annual Carolina Cup • October 2–4, 2026

Prepared with Bob Team Manager • Version 1.0 • Updated September 18, 2026